

Chapter 1: Destiny

Nerys, 23 Years Ago

Nerys Lloergan had always been on the smaller side for a half-elf. Combined with her frail constitution, it meant she was ill-suited for work in the fields—so when the time came for her to search for work, she'd instead found employment indoors, working in the food distributary further in town. It was there that she'd met Eric.

At the time, she'd only been 19—and yet, the dreary days Nerys had suffered through had taught her that she should grab on to any chance at happiness that she could get and *never* let go. When the stranger walked into the distributary that day, he'd immediately caught her eye—as well as half a dozen times more while he was in line. There was something magnetic about his presence that drew Nerys's eyes to him. He was a tall and handsome human man, perhaps a couple years older, with broad shoulders and a physique that implied—nay, *insisted*—that he worked out. Accompanying him was an equally well-built human man with dark skin, at least a few years his elder, and the two of them seemed to be good friends, judging by how amicably they'd been chatting since they got there. By the time the pair made it to the front of the line, Nerys had just one thought in her head—*get his name*.

This plan fell short, however, as the pair had arrived at the head of the line shortly after Nerys began helping another citizen retrieve the rations for their family—and thus, the captivating stranger went to one of her coworkers for aid, offering her no opportunity to speak. Nerys hadn't steeled her resolve for nothing, though—she rushed through the order and ran to catch up with the man, who'd been heading towards the door.

“H—Hey you!”

He stopped and turned to look at her—Nerys couldn't be sure over the pounding of her heart, but she swore she felt it skip a beat. Her breath caught in her throat as the brief exertion from her run caught up to her. As she tried to catch her breath, the man's brief look of confusion turned into the widest smile, radiant like a sun.

“Well, hello there, beautiful.” He looked her up and down, then gave a small bow towards her. “My name's Eric. And, if it's not too presumptuous to ask... What name might I have the pleasure of calling you by?”

“I... I’m... Ne...” Nerys’s lungs refused let her speak. This was *exactly* what she had wanted, but her body just *would not cooperate*. Frustrated, she kept trying to introduce herself, when—

“Nerys! Get back in here! Yer shift ain’t over and that line is backed out the door!” The voice of her coworker rang through her ears, her face reddening in embarrassment at the realization of what she’d done. Eric broke into a laugh—a hearty, whole-bodied laugh that eased her mind and made her feel... alive. Alive and happy about it.

“Nerys, then? I’d hate to see such a beautiful young lady get in trouble on my behalf, so perhaps you’d better get back in there.” There was a warmth to his voice, like he had been born of the Lumis itself.

“I—I will. But...” With her voice finally returned, Nerys mustered her courage once again. “Could we... maybe... talk again some other time?” Eric beamed at her.

“Of course. I’ll be back for sure.” He gave her a wave as he turned to rejoin his friend outside.

As she walked back to her station, she turned to watch Eric go. He and his friend had already started talking again—the older man broke into laughter and gave a soft punch to Eric’s shoulder. Eric’s boisterous laughter in response cut through even the noise of the crowd inside the distributary. As she watched the two of them go, Nerys had just one thought on her mind—*One day, I’m going to marry that man.*